

He's such a pain in the ass. A newly-minted Buddhist,
he offered thanks to Avalokitesvara
between bites and clasped the bathwater in jubilant bursts,
asking if I could hear the gods gurgling through the pipes.
There is something about half-dead people and gods, I swear.
Under something luminous, his vertebrae clicked
like beads on a prayer rope. When he took another bite,
syrup ran to his collarbone. I wiped it away with a
heavy sponge, not knowing where the body ended
and ruin began. The night before, I dreamt of a girl sewn
into the rafters. She whispered through the beams.
We never touched. I gargled her name
until vowels blistered the roof of my mouth.
I think it started with "X." I cannot speak in love.
Love is something that will steal your tongue and
substitute it with a pulp. There is something about nakedness—
his, hers, mine— something that doesn't ask permission.
As if want just presses itself into the soft machinery of the body.
Hunger and tenderness ferment on the same bruise.